



WGNI FARM

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

Fish Pond Management

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1. Purpose

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) defines the operational standards for the management of catfish ponds at WGNI Farm. It serves two functions simultaneously as a practical instruction guide for personnel executing daily pond tasks, and as an operational manual for management to govern, audit, and improve fish production outcomes.

This document is written exclusively for African Catfish (*Clarias gariepinus*) production and is designed to remain valid regardless of changes to the pond structure, number of sections, or scale of operation. Any physical changes to the pond system are captured in the Pond Register (Section 4) and do not require a revision of this SOP.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to all personnel involved in fish pond operations at WGNI Farm, including Fish Farm Workers and the Farm Manager. It covers the full production cycle from pond preparation and stocking through daily management, sorting, counting, health monitoring, harvesting, and disposal. It applies across all pond structures currently in use or that may be adopted in the future, including PVC tarpaulin, brick, concrete, and earthen pond systems.

3. About African Catfish

All practices in this SOP are grounded in the biology and behaviour of *Clarias gariepinus*. Understanding the fish is the starting point for managing it correctly.

Key Biological Traits

- Catfish possess a supplementary air-breathing organ (suprabranchial chamber) that allows them to gulp atmospheric oxygen directly. This makes them more resilient in low-oxygen water than most species but it does not mean water quality can be neglected.
- They are naturally nocturnal and bottom-dwelling, but cultured catfish adapt well to daytime surface feeding.
- They are highly aggressive feeders and strongly cannibalistic. Size uniformity within any pond section is essential at every stage of production.
- They have no scales. Their exposed skin is highly vulnerable to abrasion, rough handling, and infection through any wound or lesion.
- They are hardy and fast-growing under good management but deteriorate rapidly when water quality fails or disease is introduced.
- Market weight in Nigeria is typically 800g to 1.2kg, achievable within 5 to 7 months under consistent management.

Practical Implications for Management

- Sort fish regularly to maintain size uniformity and prevent cannibalism.
- Handle with care at all times rough netting, hard surfaces, and prolonged air exposure cause skin injury that leads to infection.
- Water quality must be actively managed, not merely observed.
- Feed must be high-protein and catfish-specific at all production stages.

4. Pond Register and Structural Flexibility

The Pond Register is the master record of the farm's current pond infrastructure. It is a living document updated whenever a pond section is added, removed, reconstructed, rested, or repurposed. The Pond Register decouples this SOP from any fixed physical description,

allowing these operating procedures to remain fully applicable as the farm scales or its infrastructure changes.

Field	Description
Pond ID	Unique identifier (e.g. Pond 1, Pond 2, Section A)
Structure Type	PVC tarpaulin / brick / concrete / earthen
Dimensions	Length x Width x Depth (metres)
Water Volume	Cubic metres or litres
Date Constructed / Installed	—
Current Status	Active / Resting / Under Repair / Decommissioned
Current Production Stage	Fingerling / Juvenile / Grower / Finisher / Empty
Date Last Stocked	—
Estimated Current Stock	Running count updated after each significant event
Assigned Attendant	Name of responsible personnel

The Pond Register must be reviewed and updated at every stocking, harvest, sorting event, structural change, or change in pond status.

5. Structural Guidance by Pond Type

The core catfish management practices in this SOP apply equally across all pond types. The table below identifies the key considerations that differ by structure so that personnel can adapt their inspections and maintenance accordingly.

Consideration	PVC Tarpaulin	Brick / Concrete	Earthen Pond
Leak risk	High inspect seams and folds daily	Low inspect joints periodically	Moderate monitor bund walls for seepage
Thermal stability	Low temperature shifts quickly	Moderate	High retains temperature well
Daily inspection focus	Tears, sagging walls, seam separation	Cracks, plaster spalling, joint integrity	Bund erosion, seepage, overflow
Cleaning method	Mild disinfectant, soft scrubbing	Stiff brush, disinfect between cycles	Drain, sun-dry, lime treatment
Repair urgency	Immediate small tears escalate fast	Routine cement patching	After drain earth compaction
New pond curing	Not required flush once before stocking	Mandatory cure and flush 2 to 3 weeks minimum	Mandatory lime treatment and sun-drying
Expansion ease	High new sections set up quickly	Low requires construction	Moderate excavation required

When a Structural Change Occurs

- Update the Pond Register immediately upon any change.
- For newly constructed or reconstructed brick or concrete ponds: allow a minimum of 2 to 3 weeks for cement to cure. Fresh cement leaches compounds toxic to fish. Flush and refill at least twice before stocking.
- For tarpaulin replacements: drain, clean, and inspect the frame before installing new material.
- For any pond returning from repair: complete the full Pre-Stocking Checklist (Section 6) before introducing fish.

6. Pre-Stocking Checklist

This checklist must be completed and signed off before fish are introduced into any pond section whether newly constructed, reconstructed, or returning from a rest period.

#	Check	Confirmed
1	Structure is watertight and free from visible damage	☐
2	Pond has been cleaned and disinfected	☐
3	Water has been filled and left to stabilise for minimum 24 to 48 hours	☐
4	Water colour and odour are normal	☐
5	Inlet and outlet fittings are functional and secure	☐
6	For brick or concrete ponds: curing and flushing cycle is complete	☐
7	Appropriate feed is available for the stocking stage	☐
8	Fingerling source and health status have been confirmed	☐
9	Acclimatisation procedure is prepared and ready	☐
10	Pond Register has been updated with new stocking details	☐

7. Stocking and Acclimatisation

Sourcing Fingerlings

- Source only from reputable, certified hatcheries with traceable, healthy stock.
- Confirm species (*Clarias gariepinus*), average size, and health status before purchase.
- Request that fingerlings are size-graded at the hatchery before delivery.
- Reject any batch showing signs of stress, lesions, erratic swimming, surface gasping, or abnormal discolouration.
- Record supplier name, date of purchase, quantity, average size, and cost for every batch.

Stocking Density

Stocking density must be calculated based on the water volume of each pond section, not surface area alone. Aeration capacity and water exchange frequency directly affect the density that can be supported.

Production Stage	Recommended Density
Pre-juvenile / Fingerling	100 to 150 fish per cubic metre of water

Juvenile	50 to 100 fish per cubic metre
Grower	30 to 50 fish per cubic metre
Finisher	15 to 30 fish per cubic metre

- Reduce density toward the lower end of the range if aeration is limited or water exchange is infrequent.
- As fish grow, effective density increases plan for thinning through sorting or partial harvest.

Acclimatisation Procedure

This step is mandatory for every stocking event without exception. Sudden changes in water temperature or chemistry kill fingerlings rapidly.

1. Float the supply bag or container in the pond water for 15 to 20 minutes without opening.
2. After 15 minutes, open the container and gradually introduce pond water into it over the next 10 minutes.
3. Gently tilt and release the fingerlings into the pond never pour aggressively.
4. Observe fish behaviour for the first 30 minutes fish should disperse naturally and settle.
5. Do not feed for the first 6 to 12 hours after stocking; allow the fish to settle and orientate.

8. Daily Operations

Consistent daily routine is the single most important factor in catfish pond management. The difference between a productive pond and a failing one is almost always the consistency or lack of it in daily practice.

8.1 Morning Round (No later than 7:00 AM)

1. Walk every active pond section and visually scan for dead or distressed fish. Remove any carcass immediately a dead fish left in the pond accelerates bacterial growth and can trigger an outbreak within hours.
2. Observe fish behaviour before feeding. Fish rising to the surface and gasping for air indicates oxygen depletion do not feed until the cause is identified and addressed.
3. Assess water appearance: colour, clarity, surface foam, and odour. Any abnormality must be logged and investigated before normal operations continue.
4. Inspect the pond structure: tarpaulin seams or brick joints, inlet and outlet points, frame supports, cover netting. Any damage found must be reported the same morning.
5. Carry out the first feeding round.
6. Record all observations in the Daily Pond Log.

8.2 Midday Check (12:00 PM to 1:00 PM)

1. Observe fish activity lethargic or surface-crowding fish in the middle of the day are a warning sign requiring investigation.
2. Check water level and top up if visible evaporation loss is observed especially critical during dry season.
3. Carry out midday feeding if the current schedule requires it.
4. Note ambient temperature and weather conditions extreme heat significantly depletes dissolved oxygen and must prompt additional monitoring.

8.3 Evening Round (5:00 PM to 6:30 PM)

1. Carry out the final feeding of the day.
2. Final inspection of all pond section slog any new mortalities, structural issues, or unusual fish behaviour.
3. Seal and secure all feed storage.
4. Complete the day's log entry before leaving the site.

9. Feeding Management

Feed is the largest recurring cost in catfish production. Discipline in feeding directly determines both profitability and fish health.

Core Feeding Principles

- Always broadcast feed evenly across the water surface never dump in one location.
- Observe the fish response. Healthy catfish surface-feed aggressively within seconds of feed introduction. Slow or absent response is a signal of health or water quality problems investigate before the next feeding round.
- Any feed remaining uneaten after 25 to 30 minutes is overfeeding reduce the next round accordingly and log the adjustment.
- Never feed fish that are stressed, showing disease signs, or in deteriorating water conditions. Uneaten feed in poor water accelerates the decline rapidly.
- Recalculate feed quantities after every sampling exercises fish grow, rations must increase proportionally.
- Log feed quantity consumed per pond section every day this is the primary production cost record.

Feeding Schedule by Production Stage

Stage	Fish Weight	Pellet Size	Feed Rate	Frequency
Pre-juvenile	Below 10g	Powder / crumble	10 to 15% body weight/day	4 to 5x daily
Juvenile	10g to 50g	1.5 to 2mm	5 to 8% body weight/day	3 to 4x daily
Grower	50g to 200g	3 to 4mm	3 to 5% body weight/day	2 to 3x daily
Finisher	200g and above	4 to 6mm	2 to 3% body weight/day	2x daily

- Floating pellets are strongly preferred uneaten feed is visible and can be scooped out.
- Use only catfish-specific high-protein feed. Do not substitute with poultry feed or general livestock feed.
- Minimum crude protein requirements: 40% for pre-juveniles and juveniles, 35% for growers, 32% for finishers.

10. Water Quality Management

Water quality is the environment in which the fish live. It must be actively managed not merely observed.

10.1 Daily Visual Assessment

- Colour: Light greenish or clear is acceptable. Dark green, brown, grey, or black requires investigation.
- Odour: Mild and earthy is acceptable. A sharp ammonia smell or rotten-egg odour is an emergency initiate water change immediately.
- Surface foam: Brief foam after water introduction is normal. Persistent thick foam indicates high organic load increase water exchange frequency.
- Clarity: Moderate turbidity is acceptable. Inability to see 20 to 30cm below the surface warrants attention.

10.2 Routine Partial Water Exchange

- Perform a 20 to 30% water volume exchange every 3 to 5 days under normal conditions.
- Increase frequency to every 1 to 2 days during hot weather, high stocking density, after a disease event, or following significant mortality.
- Always introduce new water slowly to prevent thermal shock to the fish.
- Borehole water should be allowed to run and aerate briefly before being released directly into the pond.

10.3 Full Water Change

A full water change is an emergency measure not a routine procedure. Carry it out only when partial exchanges can no longer restore water quality.

1. Prepare a clean, aerated holding container with sufficient volume for the fish population.
2. Net fish carefully and transfer to the holding container work quickly and gently.
3. Drain the pond section completely.

4. Scrub all surfaces with a diluted disinfectant solution (potassium permanganate or equivalent).
5. Rinse thoroughly no disinfectant residue must remain.
6. Refill and allow water to stabilise for at least 2 hours before returning fish.
7. Monitor fish closely for the first hour after return.

10.4 Target Water Quality Parameters

Parameter	Target Range	Action if Outside Range
Temperature	25 to 32 degrees C	Shade pond; increase water exchange rate
pH	6.5 to 8.5	Low pH: agricultural lime; High pH: water change
Dissolved Oxygen	Above 4 mg/L	Aerate; reduce feeding; partial water change
Ammonia (NH ₃)	Below 0.02 mg/L	40 to 50% water change immediately; suspend feeding
Turbidity	20 to 30cm visibility	Partial water change; reduce feeding rate

11. Sorting

Sorting is one of the most critical and most commonly neglected practices in catfish production. It must be scheduled and executed as a routine operation not a reaction to visible problems.

Why Sorting Matters

Even within the same batch, catfish grow at different rates. Larger fish will outcompete, intimidate, and eventually cannibalise smaller fish sharing the same section. Unsorted ponds produce poor average weights, elevated mortality, high feed waste, and uneven harvest sizes that reduce market value.

When to Sort

- First sort: 3 to 4 weeks after stocking, once size differences become visible.
- Subsequent sorts: every 3 to 5 weeks throughout the production cycle.
- Immediately, if significant size disparity or unexplained mortality is observed between scheduled rounds.

Sorting Procedure

1. Partially reduce the water level to concentrate the fish and make netting easier.
2. Use a grading net or sorting basket with appropriate mesh size fish that pass through are the smaller grade; fish retained are the larger grade.
3. Work quickly and gently prolonged air exposure and physical contact injure catfish skin and create entry points for bacterial infection.
4. Separate fish into size classes and transfer each class to its designated pond section.
5. After sorting, check and balance stocking density in all affected sections section receiving a large influx may need an immediate partial water change.
6. Adjust feeding quantities per section based on the new estimated biomass in each section.
7. Record the sort: date, sections involved, size classes separated, and approximate quantities redistributed.

Adding or Reducing Sections After Sorting

- If sorting reveals the population has grown beyond current section capacity, activate additional pond sections and update the Pond Register immediately.

- If sections are being consolidated due to harvest, mortality reduction, or restructuring transfer fish carefully, confirm density is within acceptable range, and mark vacated sections as Resting in the Pond Register.
- Never transfer fish from a section that has had a disease event into healthy stock without a minimum 5 to 7 day observation and quarantine period.

12. Counting

Accurate fish counts underpin every production and financial decision. Feeding calculations, expected revenue, cost per kilogram, and harvest planning all depend on a reliable and consistently maintained fish count.

12.1 Method 1 Direct Count at Stocking

This is the most accurate count available. As fingerlings are transferred from the supply container into the pond, two personnel count independently and reconcile their figures. This stocking count becomes the baseline for all subsequent estimates.

12.2 Method 2 Sampling Estimation (Ongoing)

For established populations, direct counting is impractical. Use the following approach:

1. Net a random sample from the pond section minimum 50 fish for small sections, 100 or more for larger volumes.
2. Count and weigh the sample precisely.
3. Estimate total pond biomass by cross-referencing sample average weight with the known or estimated total pond weight.
4. Cross-check estimated count against the running count (stocking count minus cumulative recorded mortalities).
5. Record the estimate, the sample size, date, and the method used.

12.3 Method 3 Harvest Count

At harvest, all fish are physically counted and weighed in batches. This is the definitive count for the production cycle and must be reconciled against the stocking record to establish the final survival rate.

12.4 Maintaining a Running Count

- Begin with the confirmed stocking count from Method 1.
- Subtract every recorded mortality each daily log entry must include a mortality count per section.
- Update the running count after every sorting event, partial harvest, or inter-section transfer.
- Record the current running count in the Pond Register after every significant event.

12.5 When the Count Becomes Unreliable

If the running count has been compromised by poor record keeping, an unusual mortality event, or significant sorting activity without adequate documentation conduct a full sampling exercise and reset the estimate. Log the reset with date, method, and revised figure. Do not carry forward an estimate known to be inaccurate.

13. Health Monitoring and Disease Management

13.1 Daily Health Observation

For each active pond section, observe and record the following every morning:

- Fish activity: active and responsive, lethargic, erratic, spiralling, or absent from surface.

- Feeding response: aggressive, reduced, or completely absent.
- Physical signs: ulcers, reddish patches, fin damage, swollen abdomen, pale skin, cottony patches.
- Surface behaviour: persistent gasping, jumping, or abnormal clustering near the inlet.

Any deviation from normal must be recorded in the daily log and reported to the Farm Manager the same day.

13.2 Common Conditions and Response Guide

Condition	Symptoms	Immediate Response
Oxygen depletion	Surface gasping, crowding at inlet	Stop feeding; aerate vigorously; partial water change immediately
Ammonia toxicity	Lethargy, red gills, sudden mortality	40 to 50% water change; suspend feeding for 24 hours
Bacterial infection	Ulcers, reddening, fin rot, swelling	Isolate affected fish; salt bath; consult aquaculture veterinarian
Fungal infection	White or grey cottony patches on skin or fins	Salt bath treatment; improve water quality; reduce stocking density
Parasitic infestation	Scratching against walls, erratic swimming, excess mucus	Salt bath; reduce density; veterinary advice if persistent
Nutritional deficiency	Slow growth, pale colouration, skeletal deformity	Review feed quality and protein level; switch feed brand if necessary
Cannibalism	Missing or partially eaten fish, wounds on smaller fish	Sort immediately; separate size classes; ensure feeding adequacy

13.3 Salt Bath Treatment Procedure

Salt bath treatment is for individual or small group treatment only never treat fish inside the main pond.

1. Prepare a separate clean container with aerated fresh water.
2. Dissolve non-iodised salt at the prescribed concentration typically 3g per litre for a 10-minute bath.
3. Transfer affected fish gently and observe continuously throughout the treatment.
4. Remove fish immediately if extreme stress responses are observed do not complete the full duration if fish are deteriorating.
5. Transfer treated fish into clean, conditioned water before returning to the pond.
6. Do not return treated fish to the same pond section until the water quality issue has been resolved.

14. Mortality and Disposal

Mortality management is both a health control measure and a biosecurity requirement. Dead fish left in or near the pond are a primary vector for disease spread.

14.1 Daily Mortality Protocol

1. Remove all dead fish from pond sections immediately upon discovery at every morning round, midday check, and evening round.
2. Do not handle dead fish with bare hands use a net or gloves.

- Record for each mortality event: date, pond section, approximate size or weight, and physical condition or visible cause if determinable.
- Place removed carcasses immediately into a sealed container or bag do not leave them exposed near the pond area.

14.2 Mortality Thresholds and Escalation

Mortality Level	Action Required
Below 1% of section stock in a single day	Log and monitor; continue normal operations
1 to 3% of section stock in a single day	Log, investigate water quality and fish condition; report to Farm Manager
Above 3% of section stock in a single day	Critical incident halt normal feeding; full water and health assessment; escalate to Operations Management immediately
Sustained mortality over consecutive days	Initiate disease investigation; consider partial or full water change; seek veterinary input

14.3 Disposal Procedure

All catfish carcasses must be disposed of by one of the following approved methods:

- Deep burial: Dig a pit at least 60cm deep, away from all water sources, pond perimeters, and farm access paths. Place carcasses and cover immediately with soil and lime if available.
- Composting: Where a managed compost facility exists on the farm, fish carcasses may be composted in a covered bay away from the pond area.
- Do not dispose of dead fish in open refuse, surface drains, or water bodies.
- Do not feed dead fish to other livestock without explicit veterinary clearance.
- Do not leave carcasses exposed on the ground this attracts scavengers and spreads pathogens.

14.4 After a Mass Mortality Event

Following any event in which more than 5% of a section's stock is lost within 48 hours:

- Isolate the affected pond section from all others no shared equipment without disinfection.
- Conduct a full assessment of water quality, feeding history, and any recent changes to pond management.
- Document the incident in full using the Mortality and Incident Report form.
- Do not restock the affected section until it has been fully drained, cleaned, disinfected, and refilled and at least 5 to 7 days have passed.
- Seek veterinary or aquaculture advisory input before restocking.

15. Growth Monitoring and Sampling

- Conduct a growth sampling exercise for each active pond section every 3 to 4 weeks.
- Use a cast net or seine net to capture a representative sample minimum 20 to 30 fish per section for small ponds, 50 or more for larger volumes.
- Weigh the sample batch and calculate average individual weight.
- Use the average weight to recalibrate feeding rations for that section immediately after each sampling exercise.
- Compare actual average weight against expected benchmarks for the production stage and time elapsed since stocking.

- Record all sampling data: date, pond section, sample quantity, total sample weight, average individual weight, and estimated total pond biomass.
- Use sampling results to identify underperforming sections early and investigate the cause poor growth is usually a water quality, feeding, or stocking density issue.

16. Harvesting Procedure

16.1 Preparation (24 to 48 Hours Before Harvest)

- Confirm fish have reached the target market weight through the most recent sampling data.
- Reduce or suspend feeding 24 to 48 hours before harvest to clear gut content this reduces post-harvest spoilage and improves meat quality and shelf life.
- Arrange all required equipment in advance: harvest nets, weighing scale and tare containers, water transport containers for live supply, ice or cold storage for processed supply.

16.2 Harvest Procedure

1. Partially drain the pond section to concentrate fish and facilitate netting.
2. Use soft-mesh harvest nets minimise physical injury to the fish throughout the process.
3. Work calmly and efficiently prolonged netting causes stress and increases post-harvest mortality.
4. Transfer fish immediately into oxygenated water containers if supplying live to buyers.
5. Weigh harvest in clearly measured batches and record the weight of each batch as you go.
6. Do not mix fish from different pond sections in the same harvest container without clear separation and labelling.

16.3 Harvest Records

Record the following for every harvest event:

- Date of harvest and pond section or sections harvested.
- Total fish weight in kilograms and estimated fish count.
- Average fish weight.
- Buyer name or destination.
- Sale price per kilogram if applicable.

16.4 Post-Harvest

- Calculate the Feed Conversion Ratio (FCR) for the completed production cycle: total feed consumed in kg divided by total fish weight gained in kg. A good FCR for catfish under good management is 1.2 to 1.8.
- Assess the pond section condition before deciding whether to restock, rest, or carry out a full clean.
- Mark the section status in the Pond Register accordingly.
- Restock only after the section has been properly rested, cleaned where required, and water quality confirmed stable.

17. Feed Storage and Inventory

- Store all feed in a cool, dry, well-ventilated area away from direct sunlight and moisture.
- Feed bags must be kept off the ground on pallets or shelving never stored directly on bare floor.

- Seal opened bags tightly after every feeding session to prevent moisture absorption and pest access.
- Practice First In, First Out (FIFO) always use the oldest stock first.
- Conduct a weekly feed inventory count and record remaining stock per feed type.
- Report low stock levels to management at least one week before projected depletion to allow timely procurement.
- Discard any feed showing signs of mould, clumping, unusual odour, or discolouration mouldy feed contains aflatoxins that are seriously damaging to fish liver and immune function and damage will not be visible until mortality begins.

18. Record Keeping

Accurate and consistent records are the foundation of productive farm management. The following records must be maintained for all active pond sections:

Record	Frequency	Responsible
Daily Pond Log	Every day per section	Fish Farm Worker
Pond Register	After every significant event	Fish Farm Worker / Farm Manager
Weekly Pond Summary	Every Monday	Farm Manager
Growth and Sampling Record	Every 3 to 4 weeks per section	Farm Manager
Mortality and Incident Report	Immediately as needed	Fish Farm Worker / Farm Manager
Harvest Record Sheet	At every harvest event	Farm Manager
Feed Inventory Log	Weekly	Fish Farm Worker
Sorting Record	After every sorting exercise	Fish Farm Worker

All records must be stored in the designated farm records folder (physical or digital) and made available for management review at any time.

19. Safety and Housekeeping

- No personnel should lean unsupported over pond walls the risk of falling is serious.
- Keep all walkways around the pond perimeter clear of feed bags, equipment, nets, and debris at all times.
- Wash hands thoroughly with soap after handling fish, pond water, feed, or any pond equipment.
- All electrical connections pumps, aerators, lighting must be protected from water contact and inspected regularly for wear or damage.
- Report any tarpaulin tears or structural damage immediately, regardless of size minor damage escalates rapidly.
- Cover netting over all pond sections is strongly recommended to deter birds, snakes, and rodents.
- Do not allow unauthorised personnel near the pond area without supervision.

20. Review and Amendment

This SOP shall be reviewed every six months or immediately following any significant operational incident including a disease outbreak, mass mortality event, structural failure, or significant change to pond infrastructure or production scale. All proposed amendments must be reviewed and approved by Operations Management before implementation. The Revision History table must be updated with every approved amendment.

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